Proposal to Develop a Multiuse Community School Campus

To: Superintendent and Board of Education

From: School District Planning Committee

Date: October 9, 2026

Subject: Proposal for Expanding School Facilities Into a Multiuse Community Campus

Executive Summary

This proposal recommends establishing a multiuse community campus that allows a school district to serve students while providing additional educational, recreational, and community services. Many school facilities are used primarily during school hours, leaving classrooms, meeting rooms, gymnasiums, and other spaces available for additional activities during evenings, weekends, and school breaks. By partnering with local organizations, government agencies, healthcare providers, and community groups, the district can make better use of its existing facilities while expanding opportunities for residents.

The proposed program would begin with a 12-month pilot at one school building. The campus would offer adult education classes, community meetings, after-school programs, recreational activities, health education, and other services based on community needs. The program would use existing facilities whenever possible to limit construction expenses. This proposal also includes an implementation schedule, estimated budget, funding opportunities, and methods for evaluating the program's success.

Statement of the Problem

Public schools are important community resources, but many school buildings are used primarily for student instruction during regular school hours. Meanwhile, community members may have limited access to affordable meeting spaces, educational opportunities, recreational facilities, and other local services. School districts also face the challenge of maintaining buildings and providing quality educational resources while managing limited budgets.

The article about Gaylord Community School in Michigan and Big Lake School District in Minnesota demonstrates how schools can serve a broader purpose. These campuses combine traditional education with services and activities for people of different ages. Their examples show how school facilities can become gathering places that support lifelong learning, community involvement, and neighborhood development.

Research supports exploring this approach. Everett Jones and Wendel (2015) found that formal agreements allowing communities to share school facilities can help address concerns involving liability, costs, and logistics. These agreements provide a structured way for schools and community organizations to work together. Without a coordinated plan, however, opportunities to use school facilities outside regular hours may be missed.

The district should therefore consider a practical way to expand access to existing facilities while protecting students, managing expenses, and maintaining its primary educational responsibilities.

Proposed Solution

I recommend establishing a multiuse community campus through a partnership between the school district and local organizations. Rather than immediately constructing a new building, the

district would begin by evaluating an existing school to determine which spaces could safely accommodate additional activities.

The campus would offer several services based on community interest and available resources:

- **Adult education:** Computer literacy, career preparation, financial literacy, and continuing education classes.
- **Youth programs:** Tutoring, mentoring, arts activities, and supervised after-school programs.
- **Community recreation:** Scheduled access to gymnasiums, athletic facilities, and multipurpose rooms.
- **Health and wellness:** Health education workshops, wellness events, and opportunities for qualified healthcare providers to offer approved services.
- **Community events:** Meetings, cultural performances, workshops, and other approved gatherings.
- **Intergenerational activities:** Programs that bring students, older adults, and other community members together for learning and social engagement.

The district would work with local government agencies, libraries, healthcare organizations, nonprofit groups, and businesses to identify services that could be provided through partnerships. Each organization would have clearly defined responsibilities, including staffing, scheduling, equipment, and any associated costs.

The 21st Century School Fund and the Center for Cities and Schools have emphasized that shared school facilities can provide educational, economic, and environmental benefits when districts use transparent policies and accurate financial information to guide decisions (21st

Century School Fund & Center for Cities and Schools, 2014). Following this guidance would help the district develop a sustainable program rather than simply opening its buildings without a clear plan.

Implementation Plan

The program would be introduced in four phases over 12 months.

Phase 1: Community Needs Assessment (Months 1–2)

The district would survey students, parents, employees, and community members to identify the services they need most. Administrators would review building schedules, available rooms, accessibility, safety requirements, and maintenance needs. The district would also identify potential partners and determine which activities could operate without interfering with school operations.

Phase 2: Planning and Partnerships (Months 3–4)

The district would select a pilot location and establish written agreements with participating organizations. These agreements would address scheduling, supervision, security, insurance, liability, cleaning, equipment, and financial responsibilities. Administrators would also establish procedures for background checks where required, visitor access, emergency response, and protecting students during school-related activities.

The Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC, 2025) identifies shared-use agreements as a way to define the conditions and responsibilities involved when communities access school

facilities outside regular school hours. Following this approach would help the district manage risks and clarify expectations before launching the program.

Phase 3: Program Launch (Months 5–6)

The district would prepare selected rooms, establish a reservation system, train staff, and begin offering a limited number of programs. Activities would initially operate during evenings and weekends when facilities are available. The district would promote the program through its website, community newsletters, local organizations, and public meetings.

Phase 4: Evaluation and Expansion (Months 7–12)

Administrators would monitor participation, expenses, safety, and community feedback. The district would compare actual operating costs with the original budget and determine which activities should continue. At the end of the pilot, the superintendent and school board would receive a report recommending whether to continue, revise, or expand the program.

Estimated Budget and Funding

The following figures are preliminary planning estimates for a pilot program using existing facilities. They are not contractor quotes and would need to be confirmed through a facilities assessment and discussions with potential partners.

Expense	Estimated first-year cost
Security and access-control improvements	$15,000–$30,000
Minor room renovations and accessibility adjustments	$10,000–$20,000
Additional cleaning, utilities, and maintenance	$15,000–$25,000

Program coordination and staffing	$20,000–$35,000
Equipment, technology, and program supplies	$10,000–$20,000
Insurance and administrative expenses	$5,000–$10,000
Subtotal	**$75,000–$140,000**
Contingency allowance (10%)	$7,500–$14,000
Estimated total	**$82,500–$154,000**

The district should explore several funding options to reduce the burden on its general operating budget. Potential sources include municipal contributions, community development grants, educational grants, nonprofit partnerships, sponsorships, and reasonable facility-use fees. Some services could be offered at no cost, while other organizations could pay fees based on the space used and the district's actual operating expenses.

The 21st Century School Fund and the Center for Cities and Schools (2022) provide a school facilities cost calculator designed to help districts estimate the full cost of operating shared spaces and establish fair fees. Using this resource would help administrators develop a more accurate budget and avoid underestimating the expenses associated with opening buildings to the public.

Expected Benefits and Evaluation

The proposed campus would provide benefits to students, families, and the broader community. Students could gain access to additional educational and recreational opportunities, while adults could participate in continuing education and career development. Community organizations would have more opportunities to provide services in a familiar, accessible location. The district

could also strengthen partnerships with local agencies and make better use of its existing facilities.

The district would evaluate the pilot using measurable objectives, including:

1. **Participation:** Record the number of programs offered and the number of people attending them.
2. **Facility utilization:** Compare building use during evenings and weekends before and after implementation.
3. **Financial performance:** Track operating expenses, partner contributions, facility fees, and funding received.
4. **Community satisfaction:** Conduct surveys to determine whether participants find the programs useful and accessible.
5. **Safety and operations:** Document incidents, scheduling conflicts, maintenance concerns, and compliance with established procedures.
6. **Educational and community outcomes:** Evaluate participation in adult education, youth programs, and other services using measures appropriate to each activity.

At the end of the first year, administrators would review these results and determine whether the program is meeting community needs without negatively affecting school operations. Any expansion would depend on demonstrated demand, available funding, safe operations, and evidence that the benefits justify the costs.

Conclusion and Recommendation

A multiuse community campus would allow the school district to extend its services beyond traditional classroom instruction while making better use of existing buildings. The examples of Gaylord Community School and Big Lake School District demonstrate the potential for schools to become important centers for education, recreation, health-related services, and community involvement.

I recommend that the superintendent and school board approve a 12-month planning and pilot initiative, authorize a community needs assessment, and direct administrators to identify potential partners and confirm the proposed budget. Starting with one existing facility would allow the district to evaluate the benefits and challenges before committing to larger renovations or new construction.

With careful planning, transparent financial management, and strong community partnerships, the district can create a welcoming campus that supports lifelong learning, strengthens community relationships, and uses public resources more effectively.

References

21st Century School Fund, & Center for Cities and Schools. (2014). *A policy framework for joint use: Enabling and supporting community use of K-12 public school facilities*. https://school-infrastructure.org/resources/a-policy-framework-for-joint-use-enabling-and-supporting-community-use-of-k-12-public-school-facilities-hib/

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